Georgy Porgy

By Roald Dahl

INTRODUCTION

Today's society has become all about equal rights and knocking down double standards. The Maneater has taken the dating scene by storm and she's doing it all in heels. Women have become more aggressive and have decided to take what they want instead of waiting to be chosen. This is all well and good, but NOT for the sanity of our main character. His fragile mind has concluded that the metaphor is more than a colorful description . . . How would you cope if you actually believed that women were the enemy, the attackers, the Man-eaters? Georgy Porgy by Roald Dahl.

WITHOUT in any way wishing to blow my own trumpet, I think that I can claim to being, at the ripe old age of thirty-one, a moderately well-matured and rounded individual. I speak Greek and Latin. And in addition, I have influenced the lives of others by the spoken word delivered from the pulpit.

4NG Fanatics

Yet in spite of all this, I must confess that I have never in my life--well, how shall I put it?--I have never really had anything much to do with women.

Had I been even the slightest bit ashamed of my own personal appearance, then that might possibly have explained the whole thing. But I was not. On the contrary, and though I say it myself, the fates had been rather kind to me in that regard. Good heavens above, I had seen men who were perfect shrimps in comparison with me displaying an astonishing aplomb in their dealings with the fairer sex. And oh, how I envied them! How I longed to do likewise.

But such things were not for me. Alas, I had to spend my time avoiding them instead. And this, my friends, was easier said than done. My flock, you understand, contained an inordinate number of ladies. There were scores of them in the parish. I tell you I was jumpy as a squirrel.

The spinsters in my parish . . . It's an ugly word, isn't it--spinster? It conjures up the vision either of a stringy old hen with a puckered mouth or of a huge

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

ribald monster shouting around the house in riding-breeches. But these were not like that at all. They were a clean, healthy, well-built group of females, the majority of them highly bred and surprisingly wealthy, and I feel sure that the average unmarried man would have been gratified to have them around.

But [not me] . . . and soon . . . They began to stalk me. I knew they were doing it. I could feel it happening although at first they did nothing definite to give themselves away. The first offender was Miss Elphinstone, a large woman with moles. I had dropped in on her during the afternoon to solicit a contribution towards a new set of bellows for the organ, and after some pleasant conversation, I told her not to bother to see me to the door and I went out into the hall to get my hat. I was about to reach for it when all at once I felt a bare arm sliding through mine, and one second later her fingers were entwined in my own, and she was squeezing my hand hard.

"Are you really so Very Reverend as you're always pretending to be?" she whispered.

4NG Fanatics

Well! All I can tell you is that when that arm of hers came sliding in under mine, it felt exactly as though a cobra was coiling itself around my wrist. I leaped away, pulled open the front door, and fled down the drive without looking back.

The very next day we held a jumble sale in the village hall and towards the end of it I was standing in a corner quietly drinking a cup of tea when all of a sudden I heard a voice beside me saying, "Dear me, what a hungry look you have in those eyes of yours."

The next instant a long curvaceous body was leaning up against mine and a hand with red fingernails was trying to push a thick slice of coconut cake into my mouth.

"Miss Prattley," I cried. "Please!"

But she'd got me up against the wall, and with a teacup in one hand and a saucer in the other I was powerless to resist. I felt the sweat breaking out all over me and if my mouth hadn't quickly become full of the cake she was pushing into it, I honestly believe I would have started to scream.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

A nasty incident, that one; but there was worse to come. The next day it was Miss Unwin. Now Miss Unwin happened to be a close friend of Miss Elphinstone's and of Miss Prattley's, and this of course should have been enough to make me very cautious. Yet who would have thought that she of all people. I don't propose to describe that encounter; it was too painful. And the ones which followed were no less savage. Nearly every day from then on, some new outrageous incident would take place. I became a nervous wreck. At times I hardly knew what I was doing. I started reading the burial service at young Gladys Pitcher's wedding. I dropped Mrs Harris's new baby into the font during the christening and gave it a nasty ducking. An uncomfortable rash that I hadn't had in over two years reappeared on the side of my neck; even my hair began coming out in my comb. The faster I retreated, the faster they came after me. Women are like that. Nothing stimulates them quite so much as a display of modesty or shyness in a man.

4NG Fanatics

Is it me, I kept asking myself, who is unwittingly responsible for the shameless way in which these ladies are now behaving? Is it the gleam in my eye (which I cannot control) that is constantly rousing their passions and egging them on? Or is this brutal conduct of theirs inherent in the very nature of the female?

I decided to perform a simple experiment of my own invention, using rats. There were exactly equal numbers of males and females, six of each. I first isolated the sexes, putting them into two separate cages, and I left them like that for three whole weeks. When the three weeks were up, I took a large box that was divided across the center by a little fence, and I placed the females on one side and the males on the other. The fence consisted of nothing more than three single strands of naked wire with a powerful electric current running through the wires.

To add a touch of reality to the proceedings, I gave each female a name. The largest one was Miss Elphinstone. The one with a short thick tail was Miss

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

Prattley. The smallest of them all was Miss Unwin, and so on. The males, all six of them, were ME.

I pulled up a chair and sat back to watch the result. After a while, the first male detached himself from his group and advanced gingerly towards the fence. He touched a wire and was immediately electrocuted. The remaining eleven rats froze, motionless.

There followed a period time during which neither side moved; but I noticed that while all the males were now staring at the dead body of their colleague, the females had eyes only for the males.

Then suddenly Miss Prattley could stand it no longer. She came bounding forward, hit the wire, and dropped dead. Now it was Miss Unwin who began to show signs of impatience. She snorted audibly and twitched a pink mobile nose-end from side to side. She advanced briskly to the wire, pushed her head through it, and was killed. [The remaining females perished in a similar manner.]

The five males stayed where they were, watching the slaughter.

4N6 Fanatics

I cannot tell you how much good it did me to watch this simple and rather ingenious experiment. In one stroke I had laid open the incredibly lascivious, stop-at-nothing nature of the female. I felt suddenly very strong and serene in the knowledge of my own innocence.

What I must do now, I told myself, was to weave around me a sort of invisible electric fence constructed entirely out of my own personal moral fiber. Behind this I would sit in perfect safety while the enemy, one after another, flung themselves against the wire. It was in this mood that I set off the very next day to attend Lady Birdwell's tennis party. All around me the little fence was up.

I walked towards the terrace where a group of nine or ten guests were settled comfortably in cane chairs, sipping their drinks.

"Let me fetch you a nice cooling glass of fruit cup" This last sentence came softly from someone just behind me -- a lady of singular beauty. Her name was Miss Roach. "I'm sure you must be tired after cycling

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

all that distance," she was saying now. "I'll get you some," Miss Roach said, smiling at me pleasantly. She stood up and walked over to the drink table. I saw her slicing an orange, then an apple, then a cucumber, then a grape, and dropping the pieces into a glass. Then she poured in a large quantity of liquid from a bottle whose label I couldn't quite read without my spectacles, but I fancied that I saw the name JIM on it, or TIM or PIM.

It seemed a pity to gulp it down quickly after all the trouble Miss Roach had taken to make it, but it was so refreshing I couldn't resist. I had just finished my second big glass of fruit cup when I began to experience a most peculiar sensation. I seemed to be floating up out of my chair, and hundreds of little warm waves came washing in under me. Everything around me seemed to be bobbing up and down and swirling gently from side to side. It was all very pleasant, and I was overcome by an almost irresistible desire to break into song.

"Feeling happy?" Miss Roach's voice sounded miles and miles away, and when I turned to look at her, I was astonished to see how near she really was.

4NG Fanatics

"Terrific," I answered. "I'm feeling absolutely terrific."

Her face was large and pink, and it was so close to me now that I could see the pale carpet of fuzz covering both her cheeks, and the way the sunlight caught each tiny separate hair and made it shine like gold. All of a sudden I found myself wanting to put out a hand and stroke those cheeks of hers with my fingers.

"Listen," she said softly. "How about the two of us taking a little stroll down the garden?" The very next thing I knew, I was sitting inside it on a kind of chaise-longue and Miss Roach was beside me, but I was feeling wonderful. She encircled me with her arms and squeezed my chest against hers so hard that it hurt.

Had Miss Roach or any other female tried to do this sort of thing to me an hour before, I think I would probably have fainted. I might even have died. But here I was now, the same old me, actually relishing the contact of those enormous bare arms against my body! Also--and this was the most amazing thing of all--I was beginning to feel the urge to reciprocate.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

"Kiss me," she ordered, "Come on, kiss me."

At that moment, I saw her mouth. I saw this great mouth of hers coming slowly down on top of me, starting to open, and coming closer and closer, and opening wider and wider. I can only tell you that I had never in all my life seen anything more terrifying than that mouth. The strong arms were around me, pinning me down so that I couldn't move, and the mouth kept getting larger and larger, and then all at once it was right on top of me, huge and wet and cavernous, and the next second--I was inside it.

I remember screaming for help, but I could hardly hear the sound of my own voice above the noise of the wind that was caused by the throat-owner's breathing.

Far above me, outside in the open air, I could hear the distant babble of women's voices: "It's not true... "But my dear Mildred, how awful "The man must be mad . . . A sex maniac . . . Someone ought to write to the bishop." . . . . .

4N6 Fanatics

Oh dear, oh dear. Looking back on it now, some three weeks later, I don't know how I ever came through the nightmare of that awful afternoon without taking leave of my senses. But they didn't catch me then, and they haven't caught me yet, and if my luck continues to hold, I think I've got a fair chance of evading them altogether.

All the same, this isn't such a bad place, and I have made myself as comfortable as I possibly can. There is one thing here that pleases me greatly, and that is the walls. They are lovely and soft, like a sort of padding, and the advantage of this is that I can bounce up against them as much as I wish without hurting myself.

There are several other people about, but thank God, every one of them is male. For some reason or other, they all wear white coats, and they bustle around pretending to be very busy and important. Sometimes I get so angry and frustrated with them that I lose my temper and start to shout; and then they begin backing

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

4NG Fanatics

slowly away, and saying, "Now then. Take it easy. Take it easy, vicar, there's a good boy. Take it easy."

What sort of talk is that?

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Roald Dahl
Book: Collected Short Stories of Roald Dahl
ISBN: 978-0140158076
Publisher: South Asia Books
Date (Month/Year): June 1992

AWARD HISTORY

2006 National Qualifier
2007 National Qualifier
2008 National Qualifier

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY